[Britain] has strengthened her power and her trade, has gained valuable new regions... and her world empire has increased in land-size by around 27 percent and in population by almost the same. This has resulted in a global power and position as never before; England is the only winner from this war, England together with North America: one can see an Anglo-Saxon world mastery rising on the horizon...[76]

As for India, if there had ever been doubt prior to 1914, the First World War had proved beyond measure the value of the Raj to the empire. India's armies had been instrumental in the prosecution of the war and the country had earned a reputation as 'the battering ram of British power'.[77] Indeed, Edwin Montagu (secretary of state for India, 1917–1922) made his position quite clear in 1922 in a telegram to the viceroy: 'Reports are constantly being received in England that we look upon our mission in India as drawing to a close, and that we are preparing for a retreat. Should such an idea exist, it is a complete fallacy.'[78] This determination to hold on to the empire was clear not only when it came to Britain's policies in India but also in its attempts to retain hegemony in Asia and the Middle East at large. As one historian has elegantly put it, 'if the lion had ceased to roar, it was not yet ready to lie down with the lambs.'[79]

Instead, the problem for the British government lay not in whether it should hold on to the empire, but how. And this was ultimately rooted in the concept of power. For, although officials knew the empire needed to be perceived as strong, how prestige was to be defined and measured – and therefore how it was to be maintained – was another matter. And it is here where opinion divided. Broadly speaking, for Curzon and others in the Home government, Britain's imperial position after 1918 in the likes of Persia, Afghanistan and India was best maintained by an unyielding and unwavering show of authority – diplomatic, economic and military pressure was all to be used to make foreign rulers compliant to Britain's wishes, while any groups or individuals who questioned Britain's authority were to be dealt with swiftly lest the empire appear weak. For the Indian